

POWER GRID Established 1989

With 72,500 circuit km of transmission lines, 124 sub-stations and a transformation capacity of about 82,100 MVA, it is one of the largest power transmission utilities in the world

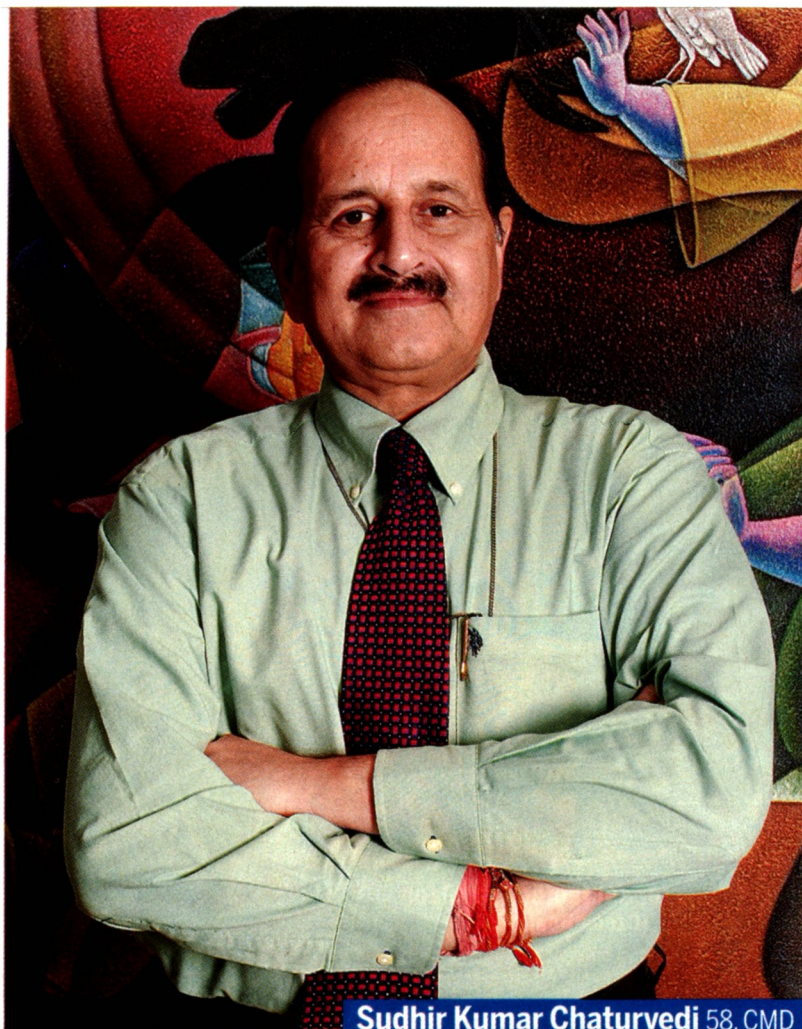
CURRENT AFFAIRS

The 1980 Rajadhyaksha Committee on power sector reforms recommended extensive changes in the country's power sector. That investment on transmission and distribution should be equal to that on power generation was one. Based on that, in 1989, the Power Grid Corporation of India (PGCIL) (formerly National Power Transmission Corporation) was set up to establish and operate regional and national power grids for transfer of electric power across India. PGCIL is not only India's largest transmission utility, piloting around 45 per cent of total power generated in the country, but amongst the largest in the world. Its activities include construction and operation of transmission systems, grid management, consultancy services, including preparation

of feasibility reports and building the 220 kV Kabul to Phul-e-Khumri transmission line and sub-station in Afghanistan, as well as for projects in Dubai, Australia and Nigeria. The company has also diversified into telecom, using its overhead transmission infrastructure—it has established over 20,000 km of fibre optic network—and has been leasing bandwidth to telecom operators like Tata Teleservices, BSNL, Reliance and Bharti Airtel.

6,571 MW
or 14.5 per cent
of the total
capacity addition
of 45,295 MW
from 1999-00
to 2008-09 was
contributed by
the private sector.

close to 72,500 circuit km of transmission lines, 124 sub-stations and a transformation capacity of about 82,100 MVA. The company was also conferred with the Navratna status last year which gave it financial and operational autonomy, including powers to approve capital expenditure for projects without monetary ceiling. Sudhir Kumar Chaturvedi, chairman and managing director of the Rs 7,029-crore company, says the company's



Sudhir Kumar Chaturvedi 58, CMD

"With our experience in transmitting power in a country as geographically diverse as India, we are all set to go global."

Few public sector companies have recorded a growth like PGCIL. In the last 17 years of operation, the company has shown a 1,009 per cent growth in turnover, a 616 per cent rise in profit and a 222 per cent increase in circuit km covered. It owns and operates

biggest strength has been its staff: "Employee empowerment has been a strategic advantage to us."

As of March, the company had transmission projects worth Rs 62,000 crore involving 38,000 circuit km of transmission lines and 44 new sub-stations with a transformation capacity of 67,000 MVA, under implementation. The company is now developing transmission systems for the evacuation of power from four ultra mega power projects—Mundra, Sasan, Krishnapatnam and Tillaiyya. Other projects include the 6,000 MW bi-pole line, the first of its kind which transmits power to over 2,000 km from Biswanath Chariyali in Arunachal Pradesh to Agra in Uttar Pradesh. Power to the nation, indeed.

by Nandini Vaish